embarrass me, but there were also moments when I would feel flattered by their admiration. But one of my rules was to avoid any close relationships with the opposite sex. Starting a romance in those days was not an option for me; I did not want any complications in my life then. I was convinced that I didn’t want any distractions that would keep me away from my goal. Besides, I was still young, and in no hurry to find my soul mate .

I had the full support of the army during these years when my demanding practice routine had taken over my life. My regiment gave me extra food and milk and I was exempted from the regular military duties so that I could concentrate on my training. My victories made my regiment very happy, more so because by setting new records, I was also bringing glory to the armed forces.